



When to use which leadership style

A three-year study of 3,000 managers led psychologist Daniel Goleman to uncover six distinctive styles of leadership. Each style has a significant impact on how

people feel about their work. The most effective leaders master a number of styles and use them appropriately according to the situation.

	Style	When to use	Drawbacks
Affiliative 	"People come before task." Focuses on creating emotional bonds within a team and a sense of belonging within an organization.	Use in times of stress, when teammates need to recover from trauma, or when the team needs to rebuild trust.	Praise and nurturing can foster mediocre performance and lack of direction.
Coaching 	"Try this." Helps people find their strengths and weaknesses, linking these to career aspirations and action.	Use to help teammates build lasting personal strengths that make them more successful.	Coaching is ineffective when teammates are defiant and/or unwilling to change or learn, or if a leader lacks ability.
Commanding/ coercive 	"Do what I tell you." Demands immediate compliance, without discussion or negotiation.	Only use in times of crisis or to control a problem employee when all else fails.	Insistence should only be used when essential; it can alienate people, stifle inventiveness, and create a tense atmosphere.
Democratic 	"What do you think?" Goal is to build consensus through participation.	Use when it is necessary for the team to buy into or have ownership of, a decision, plan, or goal.	This is not for use in crisis or when teammates are not well enough informed to be able to offer suitable guidance to the leader.
Pacesetting 	"Do as I do, now." Expects and models excellence, creating challenging and exciting goals for the team.	Only use when the team is already motivated and competent, and when fast results are necessary.	Style can overwhelm some team members and adversely affect employee commitment; it may stifle creativity and innovation.
Visionary/ authoritative 	"Come with me." Mobilizes the team toward a common vision and goal, leaving the means up to the individual.	Use when the team needs a new vision because circumstances have changed, or when explicit guidance is not required.	This is not effective when a leader is working with a team of experts or better-informed group.